

DEMONS AND THE BIRTH OF THE MODERN WITCH

demonology in Renaissance Europe

For educated Europeans in the Renaissance period, demons were central to their ideas about sorcery and witchcraft. Such beings were thought to be wicked spirits able to access occult powers, but only within the limits of the natural world created by God. Demonology (the study of demons) drew on earlier cultures, including Mesopotamian beliefs about demons and evil gods (see pp.18–21), early Islamic *jinn* (see pp.78–81), and ancient Greek guardian spirits (one word for such a spirit was *daimon*). Early Christian thinkers built on these ideas; for example, Augustine asserted that demons existed and that they could enter people's bodies.

◀ Into the jaws of hell

This 16th-century woodcut shows Lucifer and demons at the jaws of hell. Christian tradition held that Lucifer was a fallen angel who became Satan, God's deadly adversary.



Work of the Devil

For Christians, the Devil—also known as Satan, Lucifer, Baal, or Beelzebub—was the prince of demons, who were his helpers. This arch-demon was at the center of Renaissance demonology, a fact that both anchored the study of demons in Christian belief and encouraged charges of heresy against people said to practice demonic magic. In the preface to his *De la démonomanie des sorciers* (1580s), French philosopher and jurist Jean Bodin quoted an earlier text explaining that pacts with demons must be avoided. It states: "... the demon is judged to be an undaunted and implacable adversary of God and man."

Demons were also said to submit to the power of a biblical figure, King Solomon—hence the importance of Solomonian ritual, which invoked holy powers with the aim of gaining control over demons, in ceremonial magic (see p.143).

Know them by their name

Influenced by Christian hierarchies of angels, occult texts in the Renaissance era often listed the names of demons in order of importance, along with details on ways to summon each of them to perform specific sorcery. Different versions of such classification systems circulated, notably the one in the *Ars Goetia* section of *The Lesser Key of Solomon* (mid-1600s), which listed 72 demons. This Solomonian list is thought to be based on the *Pseudomonarchia daemonum* ("False Monarchy of Demons") that formed part of Dutch physician Johann Weyer's *De praestigiis daemonum* (1563).

◀ Arrows of evil

In *The Pilgrim's Progress* (1678–1684), English preacher John Bunyan describes Beelzebub and his devilish helpers as deadly archers, as in this 19th-century illustration of the work.



▲ Exorcising demons

This French engraving from the 17th century depicts St. Catherine exorcising a demon from a woman as other winged demons flee from the scene. The possessed woman's body forms the shape of a crucifix.